

~~How do we deploy AI?~~

Companies are asking **the wrong question** about AI.

IN THIS BOOKLET

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Since ChatGPT launched, companies have been scrambling to deploy AI — or at least look like they are.

Boards want a plan. Employees want career clarity. Customers want more.

So, the question is: How do we deploy AI?

Some companies seem to have an answer. They've hired consultants. They've got pilots running. They've sent out a strategy email from the CEO.

But, beneath the surface, it feels like performance, or FOMO, or new names for old ideas. The AI box is checked, but it's still business as usual.

They don't have a thesis for using AI to win.

The problem is the question, because “deployment” is the wrong goal. Instead, the right question is: What's possible now? How has the landscape shifted, and how do the business's larger goals, strategy, way of working have to change?

You don't need an AI strategy. You need a new direction, adapting to and taking advantage of AI. Then, adoption can follow direction.

Every company will have to ask the right question soon. The companies that are ready now can pull ahead.

If you're one of them, let's talk.

The wrong question

AI companies see a new industrial revolution. **Do you?**

>\$600bn

CAPITAL SPENDING

by the five largest technology companies in 2026 — four times what they spent in 2022.

75%

OF C-SUITE EXECUTIVES

say their company's AI strategy is “more for show” than for actual internal guidance.

Sources: **note 1**, at the back.

The scale and ambition of AI investment is difficult to grasp. AI companies are designing new chips, erecting vast data centers, and training breakthrough models. **They're betting on a revolution.**

So far, it's not happening. Companies aren't seeing value yet that matches the hype. AI initiatives get abandoned, employee uptake is slow, and leaders admit their strategy is mostly for show.

At the heart of that gap is the wrong question: “How do we deploy AI?”

FIRST

AI ≠ IT.

SECOND

**There is no
playbook.**

THIRD

**Maturity can
hold you back.**

FIRST

AI $\neq$ IT.

Take a look at the latest insights from consultants on what it takes to deploy AI:

- strong leadership
- trust
- building capabilities and readiness
- committing to transformation

Now look back 10 years at what they said it takes to execute “digital transformation”:

- strong leadership
- trust
- building capabilities and readiness
- committing to transformation

It's a find-and-replace. And it limits what AI can do for you.

IT

improves your current business.



Find deployment opportunities.



Deploy.

IT plays a supporting role. IT helps execute, but usually doesn't define strategy.

AI

creates new possibilities.



Define an expansive thesis.



Build.

AI is in a different category. The capabilities it offers demand a strategy conversation, not an adoption plan.



AI changes what you can do, so it has to change your ambition. **You can't bolt AI onto business as usual.**

There is no playbook.

AI broke into the mainstream in late 2022. By early 2023, as even tech companies scrambled to keep up, consultants were already pitching AI playbooks.

Playbooks give consultants repeatable business and clients the comfort of a tried-and-true approach. **But AI playbooks are absurd.**

It's far too early for best practices.

Nobody has a grip on what really works yet, not even the companies building the technology. What looks true today might be wrong in a month.

AI's value is its adaptability.

AI is a leap in capability precisely because it is endlessly adaptable. Traditional software runs on rails; AI makes choices. Traditional software serves a customer base at scale; AI can be tailored precisely. A playbook is a good way to miss most of the value.

Good isn't the goal.

Best practices are, by definition, things that everyone can adopt. AI is a generational opportunity for differentiation, and it won't come out of a playbook.



Maturity can hold you back.

Sooner or later, you'll come across an AI maturity framework, like this:

Experimenting → Implementing → Building → Scaling

A clear progression is comforting. But getting to “maturity” in the wrong approach is **worse than a distraction**. It can hold your real work back:

Losing what matters.

The most unique things about your company—your customer relationships, carefully-selected talent, culture and institutional knowledge—can get swallowed by cost cutting and automation. AI maturity can destroy your differentiation.

Organizational resistance.

A rushed deployment builds up debt. Being forced to use flashy but ill-fitting tools or watching colleagues replaced by bots kills receptivity to change.

A check-the-box mindset.

Getting a few AI things looks like progress and can become an excuse for losing focus.

We look like a success story, because we're shipping a lot of AI things. But there's no vision.

There's a real opportunity and we're not touching it.

The right question

If tomorrow an additional 50% appeared in your budget, **you'd have ideas right away.**

You might hire additional staff, or invest in product quality. You might finally take on that someday project.

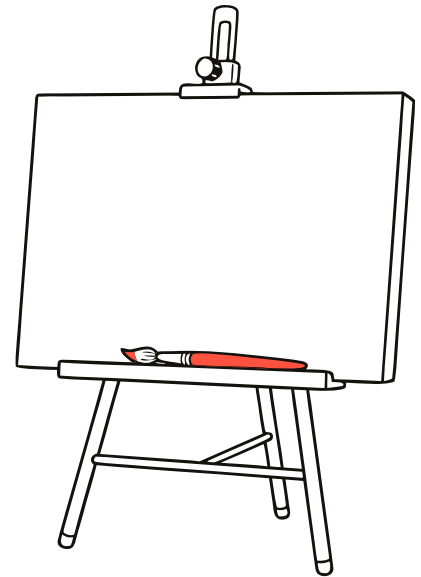
AI is a windfall like that, but instead of a flood of ideas, companies aren't sure what to do.

That's because leaders have always imagined what they'd do with more resources, but we don't have practice thinking about AI that way.

To see the opportunity, ask:

What's possible now?

What can you build? Which customers can you reach?
What new ways can you organize and work?



The answer is worth the investment. Here's how we approach it.

FIRST

Define your singular thesis.

SECOND

See beyond the immediate.

THIRD

Think in ingredients.

FIRST

Define your singular thesis.

A thesis is the single, clear idea that connects action to goals in context.

Astonishingly, many companies — even and especially very successful ones — skip to planning and execution. Later, when their initiatives have stalled or simply failed, they wonder how they got there.

You need a thesis that's:

Durable

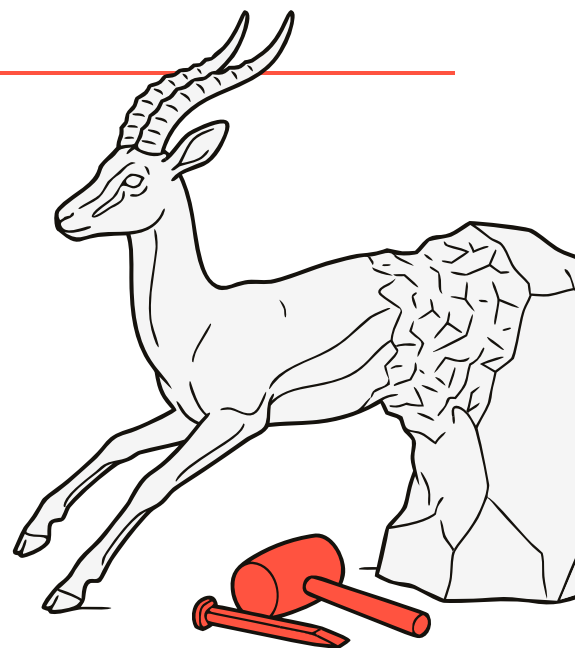
A vague mission statement is meaningless; a thesis should be the knife that cuts away options. A detailed plan will crash on the rocks quickly, and that's worse than vague: it's discredited. A good thesis lasts: sharp enough to inform decisions, flexible enough to adapt to circumstances.

Galvanizing

Eventually, you have to move from dipping a toe in the water to diving in. That's the only way to get the whole organization working together. A strong thesis makes the commitment clear.

Idiosyncratic

The core value of AI is that it is adaptable — it can fit your highly specific needs in a way no previous tool has. Doing the same thing as everyone else is a waste of the opportunity.



You can afford to invest now in getting the thesis right. You can't afford to spend the next few years getting it wrong.

See beyond the immediate.

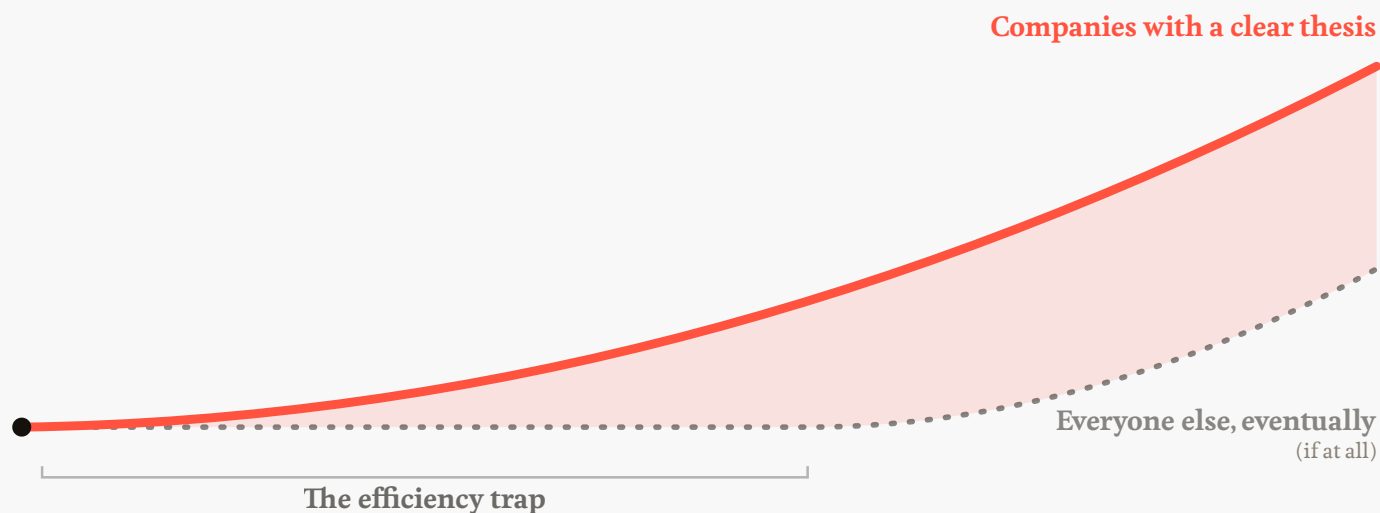
Everyone's going to have to figure out long-term value, eventually. **Winning companies get there first.**

Treat efficiency as a means, not an end.

We're told that AI is all about efficiency: automate tasks, cut headcount, boost the bottom line. CEOs are boasting about the jobs AI will replace.

Doing the same work with half the people looks good today. **The long-term win is twice the value from the people you have.**

If you find expansive opportunities now, investing your savings in expansion, you have a window of opportunity to differentiate and pull away.



Invest in capacity.

Off-the-shelf AI is quick, easy — and commoditized. Build the internal capacity to develop your own AI value that can't be copied.

Focus on post-AI value.

AI fatigue is inevitable; actually, it's already here. When people are tired of talking to bots and dealing with automated everything, what stands out? Human connection and imperfection, unexpected ideas, unique taste — **invest here.**

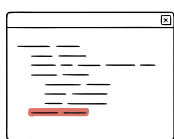
Think in ingredients.

Because it's hard to know how to use AI, packaged solutions are proliferating. The support chatbot. The embedded productivity tools. The process automation agents.

Shrink-wrapped ideas can work, but they'll never differentiate you, because they're identical to what everyone else is buying.

The best packaged solution is still a fraction of AI's value.

Instead, think in terms of the ingredients that let you experiment and build.



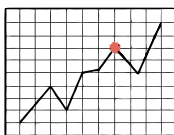
Code. Writing software, from simple plugins to fully-featured applications to complex backend processes.

+



Creation. Generating raw content (text, image, video, etc.), but also reshaping, repackaging, and translating existing content between contexts, formats, and audiences. The possibilities are much more interesting than “draft an email for me.”

+



Analysis. Rapid, even real-time, analysis of streams of data, even when not fully structured and scrubbed.

+



Facilitation. Helping team members, across functions and time zones, work through issues, get to a common understanding, and execute.

+



Execution. Carrying out work assigned by humans (i.e., agents).

These aren't solutions. The breakthrough value is in how you combine them for your specific context.

Why belari

belari exists to help you reimagine what you can do

We close the distance between the technology and a vision worth the work.

belari begins with deep understanding.

The reality of a company is richer than what's captured in data. The way decisions are made, the shared beliefs, the blind spots.

Over years leading strategy, I learned the hard way that analytical rigor is only a part of the work. What makes sense on paper has to be something the company can absorb and execute.

That's why I won't articulate a thesis and won't start talking about AI without understanding:

What is this team trying to accomplish? Not what it wants from AI, but where it wants to be in the market. Not the target but the vision, one that doesn't bake in assumed constraints.

What are the constraints that have made it impossible? What's narrowing the ambition? What

barriers do we need to break through?

What are the team's convictions? How does this team see the world? What is it willing to chase, even if the odds are long? What is it unwilling to try, even if the path looks clear?

AI is a technological breakthrough. It will only create breakthrough value if it becomes a part of the way a company really thinks and works.

We're trying to get this right. We've put good rules in place, but they're more defensive than forward-looking. We've got people who are all-in and skeptics, and we haven't agreed on what we're working toward.



Nick Pyati

I led strategy teams at Microsoft for nine years, across business units, functions, and geographies. Most recently, I led strategy for Windows and defined the team's thesis for the AI era.

Clear, thesis-driven leadership through uncertainty was the core of that work. Now, AI is bringing that pace of change to every industry. I started belari to bring lessons learned in the AI transition to every company.

Before Microsoft, I was a project leader with Boston Consulting Group in the Public Sector and Energy practices. I've taught public school in New York, served as a federal prosecutor, and run for Congress.

How we work

PART I: ~6 WEEKS

01 Find the barriers.

What's the vision you've never believed possible? The market you've never been able to crack? The reorganization that would make your team more effective?

This isn't AI in search of a problem. It's the real challenges standing in your way.

02 Identify the breakthroughs.

We take the AI "ingredients" and map them to your barriers to see how AI can break through.

03 Craft the thesis.

We define your thesis for AI: durable, galvanizing, and idiosyncratic. Not how to deploy AI in a vacuum, but how to use it to get to your broader vision. We invest in getting it right.

04 Decide on initiatives.

We decide on the first initiatives to put the thesis into practice and start building AI capability. **This isn't testing the water. This is the moment you commit.**

PART II: TO DISCUSS, BASED ON PART I

05 Plan for internal capacity.

Winning is going to take internal AI capability. That could be in-house designers and developers, more resources and autonomy for IT, recruiters who know how to look for AI proficiency. We'll figure out what you need and plan for putting it in place.

06 Launch it.

We do action, not performance. We'll help set targets (business targets, not adoption metrics), put leaders in charge, and make sure the whole organization understands the thesis.

What's possible for you now?

Let's find out. hello@belari.ai

NOTES

01

Capital spending, and the survey

Capital spending: total property and equipment from the 10-Q filings of Amazon, Google, Meta, Microsoft and Oracle, via Federal Reserve Board, FEDS Notes, July 2026, figure 4. The exact figure behind the rounded headline is \$624 billion, against roughly a quarter of that in 2022. Not all of it is AI.

The 75%: WRITER, “AI adoption in the Enterprise,” 2026, fielded by Workplace Intelligence between 17 December 2025 and 25 January 2026. 2,400 respondents in the United States, the United Kingdom, Ireland, Benelux, France and Germany, of whom 1,200 are C-suite; the 75% is the C-suite figure. WRITER sells AI software.

02

Quotations

The remarks set in coral through the book are paraphrased from real conversations with leaders at companies weighing what to do about AI. They are not verbatim, and no company or individual is identified.